

PROPERTYPLUS

HOMES AND REAL ESTATE NEWS

THE HINDU



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TN/2/Layout/1030/2025
dated: 25.03.2025
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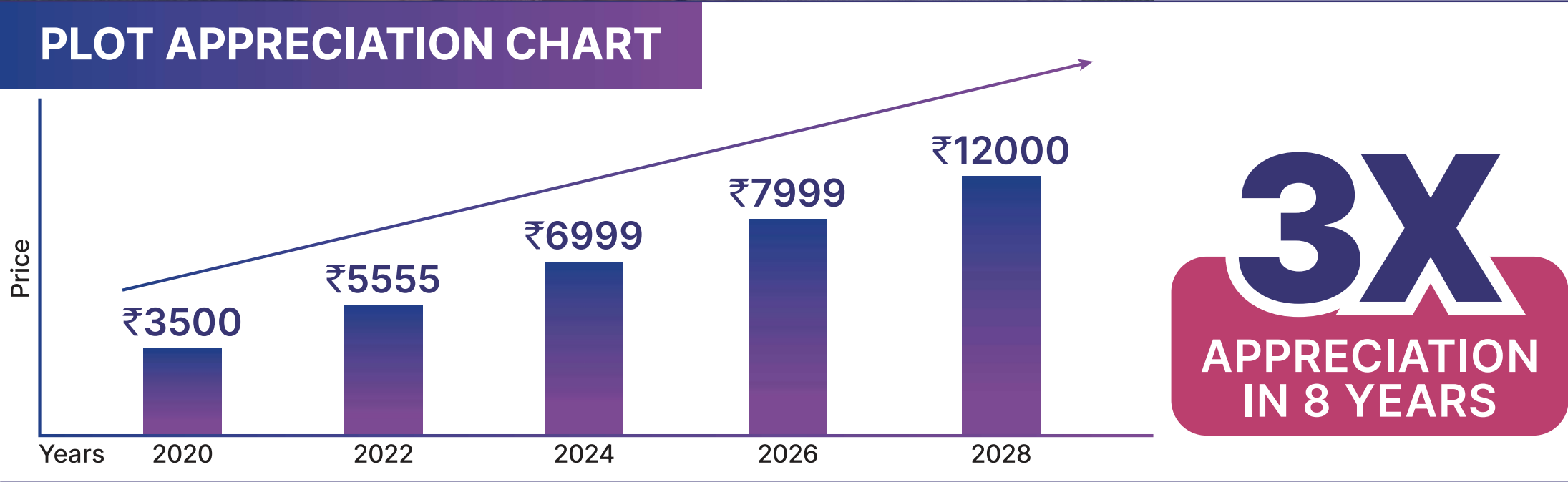
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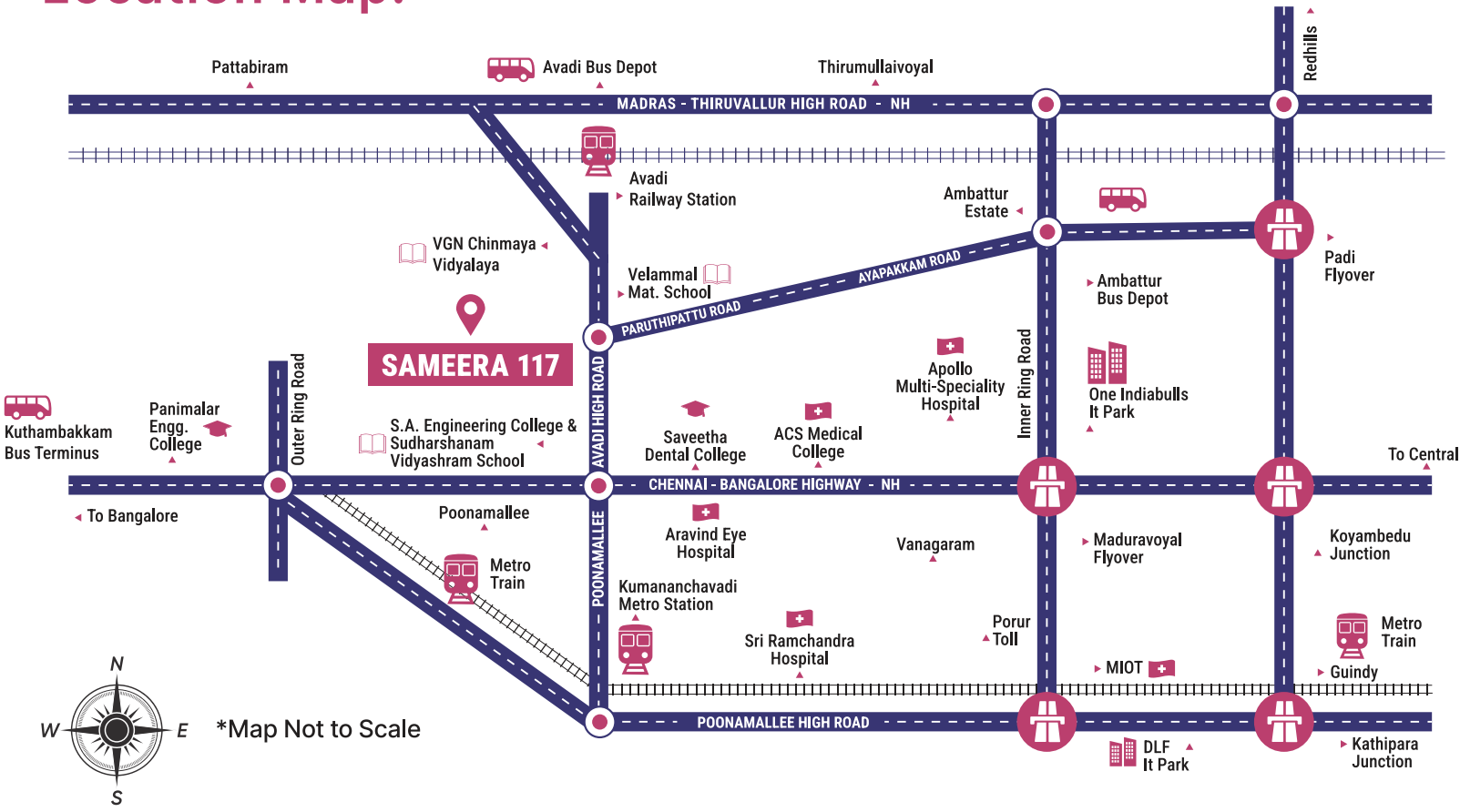
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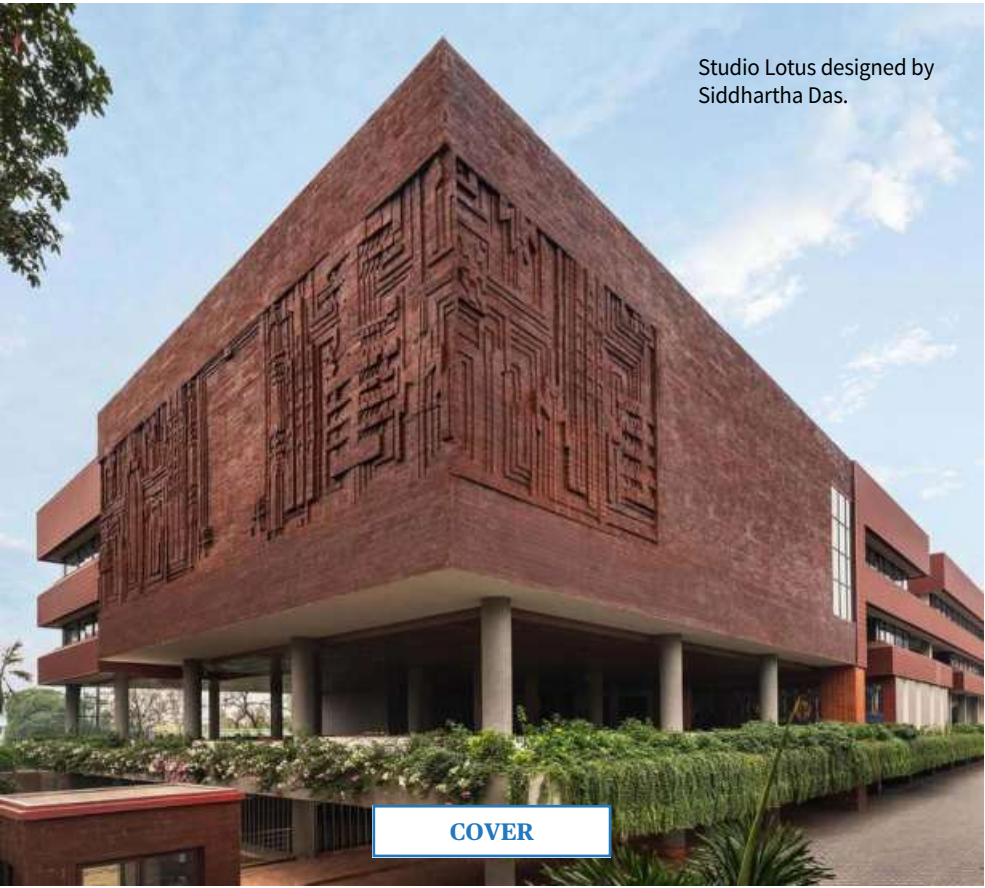
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PROPERTYPLUS

HOMES AND REAL ESTATE NEWS

THE HINDU



Studio Lotus designed by Siddhartha Das.

COVER

Finding stepwells in modern architecture

Designer and curator Siddhartha Das is inspired by third spaces in ancient India. An exhibition in New Delhi showcases craft, memory and material in his practice

Anisha Menezes

How does temple architecture and stepwell detailing inform modern interior décor? Do the spatial design and mathematical calculations of third spaces in ancient India influence the way artists and

designers envision modern Indian museums, galleries, stores or even homes? The Siddhartha Das Studio was founded two decades ago by New Delhi-based designer, artist and curator Siddhartha Das. Siddhartha works at the intersection of modern design, industrial processes and Indian craftsmanship.

He is inspired by his lifelong tryst with art, artist training workshops across 15 Indian states, and designing. Siddhartha grew up surrounded by Odisha's local textile and art forms, thanks to his father.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 3

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TN/29/BUILDING/0396/2024

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In the shadow of Alamparai Fort

Rosella Stephen

What came first, the coconut grove or En Vilasam? According to its architect, Raj Andagere, this gem-like private villa on the Alamparai coast, began with a sun-dappled gathering of coconut trees that seemed to lean toward one another.

When its late owner, Gomathi Subramanian, an antiques collector from Chennai, chanced upon them, her mind was set. She was eager to get out of the city and this little fishing hamlet between Mamlapuram and Pudukcherry was the solution. Backed by her Chettinad roots, a book on the mansions in Karaikudi by renowned architectural historian George Michell, and warehouses filled with antiques, she had a clear idea of what she wanted. It was then up to Auroville-based Andagere to balance nostalgia and a unique contemporary language.

"It was clear to me, what she wanted to build. We wanted to retain the spirit of those mansions and yet evolve," says the architect who, with his brother Ajith, specialises in vernacular, craft-based, and eco-friendly design. "The crux of the house is important. We knew that the house had to revolve around those trees," he explains.

What he created blended with the landscape and yet bore the fingerprint of its owner. Take the entry point, with its deliberately high walls, flanked by two policemen statues. "We purposely used nar-

A holiday home in a fishing village near Chennai celebrates the spirit of Chettinad but with a different accent and sensory quality

row doors so you only see the reflection of the water," says Andagere. Once you enter, a sequence of openings along the verandah reveal little bits of this Tamil home: sunlight glancing off the surface of a koi pond in place of a courtyard, ancient granite columns, a bridal wooden chest a staircase, louvered French accordion doors, Tanjore art, old family photos, hand-plastered ochre walls. "Humans are curious creatures," he points out, so the idea was to encourage visitors to discover something new along the way.

Open to guests

About three years ago, when Chennai-based villa rental company, LuxUnlock, met with En Vilasam's current owner, Anjan Rangaraj and added this property to their portfolio, guests from across the country were able to enjoy this experience. "Gomathi has many stacks of these doors. The stone columns had spots of paint and we chose not to clean them up. It was a bit of a puzzle, putting this place together with her antiques and our design," Andagere continues. And the biggest challenge? "The place came with nine roofs, given the rectangular-shaped site and the courtyard and verandahs," he says. Coconut rafters sourced from Karnataka were used throughout the house to bring down the expenses. Each of the three bedrooms in this home



has a distinct character and opens out into the verandah, with the bathrooms hand-plastered an emerald green or lapis lazuli. Brass accessories, cheeky wooden birds and other details ensure that every visitor goes back with memories.

"Most guests say the home feels 'unexpected'. They don't quite know where to place it initially, because it doesn't follow a predictable luxury-villa aesthetic. There are strong Tamil coastal influences, Chettinad references and antique elements, but everything has been interpreted in a very personal and free-spirited way," explains Ashish Gupta, founder LuxUnlock. There is a blend of rituals and fluid design here. You can stop at a semi-circular showering stall at the entrance to wash away the sand from the silky smooth beach nearby or settle

down with a book in the lounge overlooking the lush tropical garden. A bamboo reed roof and a table built from reclaimed catamaran logs and old railway benches is the ideal setting as you plan the day's ac-



"En Vilasam is a reflection of Gomathi's mind, her taste, and the way she saw the world. It stands as both her legacy and a quiet continuation of her artistic mind. This was a home she built to share and be appreciated and I wish to do the same."

ANJAN RANGARAJ,
present owner

Alamparai Fort is a short boat ride away (L); at En Vilasam, hand-plastered walls, old doors, collected artefacts, Chettinad furniture and and gem-like bathrooms offer nspiration. SUNDEEP KUMAR



tivities – perhaps a visit to the crumbling 18th century fort of Alamparai or a local fish meal at a small restaurant nearby.

"The open-to-sky bedrooms, hand-plastered walls, old doors, bold colours and collected artefacts make it feel more like someone's artistic home than a designed hospital-ity space," continues Gupta.

"I think people also respond instinctively to the sensory quality of the house. The sea breeze moves through the corridors, there's water reflecting light into the rooms, and the textures are all very tactile – stone, lime plaster, old wood, brass. It feels lived-in rather than styled," he concludes. Details: www.luxunlock.com



What I love about it is that it doesn't try to be conventionally luxurious. It is earthy, eccentric in parts, deeply Tamil in its references, and very atmospheric. The house opens itself slowly – through antique objects, changing light, the sound of water around the koi pond, glimpses of palms and sea beyond. The setting also adds so much character. You are in a quiet fishing village beside the ruins of Alamparai Fort, and life still moves at an older coastal rhythm there. Guests often arrive expecting a beach villa, but leave talking about the feeling of the place instead.

ASHISH GUPTA,
founder, LuxUnlock

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Various artworks by Siddhartha Das and Chiara Nath at display.

Finding stepwells in modern architecture

CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

His father, Jatin Das – a painter, poet, sculptor, muralist, printmaker, teacher, and cultural expert – was the driving force behind his passion.

Channelling Odisha

Among his many projects, inspired by Odisha's rich Kalinga temple architecture, its Sambalpuri ikat weaves and agricultural diversity, Siddhartha Das Studio created a 28x10 metre rich sculptural facade in laterite, in conjunction with Studio Lotus, that wraps around the Biju Janata Dal headquarters in Bhubaneswar.

A tribute to Odisha's history and landscape, seen through a contemporary lens, inspired Siddhartha to create three works. These include two patinated brass wall art pieces and



one wooden sculptural mural draw on the laterite facade. The works are part of *The Space Between: A Twenty-Year Retrospective of Design and Sculpture*. The exhibition explores the spaces between material and memory, form and function, and craft and contemporary

sensibilities. It began this month and ends on May 3 at Ojas Art Gallery, New Delhi.

Siddhartha presents 50 works based on architectural themes. They bring together contrasts of scale, intricacy, modernity, and history, all interwoven with craft traditions.



Nine of these pieces are not for sale.

The exhibition also includes 18 works by multidisciplinary designer Chiara Nath, who has collaborated with Siddhartha at his stu-



dio over the past two years.

The Siddhartha Das Studio works across retail, public and private spaces.

A 2024 design of a *puja* room at a client's residence was adorned with an exquisite marble sculptural expression of *Yagya Narayan* (avatar of Lord Vishnu), serving as the focal point of the space, with its walls punctuated by intricate stepwell patterns. Stepwells are a recurring design motif with Siddhartha, with water architecture interpretations being applied to interior spaces.

Temple spirit

The Lingaraj Temple was recreated in wood by the stu-

dio for the Lingaraj Interpretation Centre in Odisha. Now art collectors can own a smaller version of the masterpiece, on sale at the exhibition, in iterations as a temple complex and just the *shikara* (top).

"There is a certain excitement to work with juxtaposition! We draw from diametric opposites like silence and music, light and shadow, forms and counterfoils, profuse carving or embroidery with spaces around – the duality is interesting. We are fascinated by both the fragility and strength of materials, whether wood, stone, cloth or bone inlay," he says.

Airport installation

The Ashtamangala installation at the international arrivals terminal at Bengaluru airport is also part of the exhibition. It includes two Ashtamangala works, both done in pen on

paper. The airport mural draws on the idea of eight (*ashta*) auspicious offerings. They are reimagined as sculptures inspired by the Chola tradition and are placed in front of a large Mysore-style painting.

The design project 'Ripple' at the exhibition was initially created as a private commission piece, and is available for sale at the exhibition as a large lime plaster punctuated by geometric camel bone inlay work. "We sourced the camel bones from Jodhpur (from animals that died naturally), using long leg bones that offer a mother-of-pearl-like texture but without the lustre," he says.

Enter the museum

As part of Siddhartha's practice, the studio's work also spans retail, museum and institutional design. This includes the Swadesh Masters' Pavilion at the Art Deco Eros Cinema building in Mumbai. It has also designed the interiors and visitor experience for the Museum of Meenakari Heritage in Jaipur.

Ode to Jatin Das

For now, the studio has a busy year in store, with projects across the country. Siddhartha explains, "We are working on the J.D. Centre of Art (across the historic 2nd century BCE Khandagiri caves in Bhubaneswar, Odisha), which will house my father's (artist Jatin Das) art collection of around 9,000 pieces from 35 countries. Architect B.V. Doshi designed the building for this centre that will house galleries and spaces that we hope to open by 2027."

As Indian artforms are the bedrock of artistic expression at Siddhartha Das Studio, its vast repertoire is proof that ancient motifs can be married with modern material and sensibilities to craft elegant interior spaces.

The Space Between exhibition at Ojas Art Gallery, New Delhi.

The freelance writer is based in Chennai.

IN STORES

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		LABOUR	
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P. SAND	₹60/- per cft	MEN	Per day ₹850/-
M.SAND	₹70/- per cft	WOMEN	Per day ₹750/-
		PAINTER/ PLUMBER	Per day ₹1,000/-
		CARPENTER	Per day ₹1,000/-

Source : Builders Association of India (Southern Centre) Inclusive of taxes

FIVE YEAR FOCUS

A weekly round-up of indicative property prices in one area of Chennai that shows how the value of real estate has moved over the last five years.

THIS WEEK: CHROMEPET

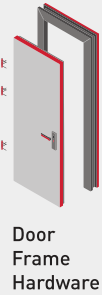
Realty Rates

Segment	2021 (INR per sq ft)	2026
Luxury Apartments	6,500	10,500
Premium Apartments	5,000	8,600
Budget Apartments	4,300	7,900

Source: JLL

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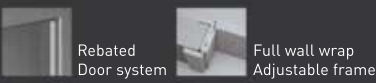


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Mitu Mathur

India’s urban transition is no longer defined solely by outward expansion. With redevelopment projects already reshaping existing colonies across metropolitan regions, particularly in Delhi, a more consequential opportunity is emerging: to treat these interventions as working prototype neighbourhoods. These are not pre-designed models, but live redevelopment sites where strategies can be tested, observed, and refined over time to inform the future of urbanisation in India.

Densification in India is often seen as a compromise, associated with congestion, infrastructure pressure, and a decline in quality of life. But this perception comes less from density itself and more from how it has been executed in the past.

Instead of treating redevelopment as a numbers game focused on housing or land value, these projects can be used to test how neighbourhoods actually function. Architect and theorist Christopher Alexander argued for a similar approach, which he described as piecemeal growth – an approach in which cities evolve through small, continuous, and context-responsive interventions rather than large, rigid master plans imposed at scale. His proposition was simple: urban environments function better when they are allowed to adapt incrementally, guided by real feedback rather than abstract projections.

Areas in capital

India’s current phase of redevelopment offers a comparable moment. With the redevelopment of multiple



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India’s urban prototype moment

Delhi’s redevelopment projects are turning neighbourhoods into live sites to test how density can work

colonies underway in Delhi, each site has the potential to become part of a larger learning process. Among these, the redevelopment of Sarojini Nagar and Netaji Nagar can be understood not just as projects, but as early working prototypes of how Indian cities might densify in the future. They reflect both the scale and ambition of this shift, involving a transition from low-rise government housing to significantly denser, high-rise configurations. As these neighbourhoods take shape, they allow us to understand, over time, how density, mo-

bility, infrastructure, and public space come together in practice.

The question, however, must move beyond how much we can build to how well these neighbourhoods can function. Sarojini Nagar and Netaji Nagar offer a rare chance to understand how neighbourhoods operate as integrated systems, where density is not an isolated metric but something experienced through daily life. A well-planned dense neighbourhood can support what is often called a “5-minute neighbourhood”, where most daily needs are

within walking distance. This reduces dependence on long commutes and creates a more local, grounded way of living. In this sense, density is not about fitting more into less space; it is about bringing more within reach.

Much of India’s urban movement is still structured around fragmented networks, where residential clusters, workplaces, and amenities remain disconnected. Redevelopment presents an opportunity to reorganise this relationship.

In the case of Sarojini Nagar and Netaji Nagar, their locations within

the city’s core mean that the focus shifts from creating new access to strengthening existing systems.

Social infrastructure

Climate and infrastructure also need to be a part of the same conversation. Dense environments can perform well when they are designed with attention to orientation, materials, ventilation, and landscape. These decisions affect thermal comfort and resource use in a real way. At the same time, social infrastructure cannot be treated as an afterthought. Schools, healthcare, community spaces and informal gathering points all play a role in how a neighbourhood functions.

Another important aspect is how these projects are financed and delivered. One approach that is gaining

The redevelopment of Sarojini Nagar and Netaji Nagar can be understood not just as projects, but as early working prototypes of how Indian cities might densify in the future

traction is to prioritise the development of commercial spaces and markets early in the process. In Sarojini Nagar, for instance, the restructuring and strengthening of its existing market is positioned as a key part of this logic, ensuring that economic activity is embedded within the neighbourhood rather than added later.

This also helps ensure that neighbourhoods are active from the outset, rather than becoming purely residential zones that rely on other parts of the city.

In this context, the idea of prototyping aligns closely with Alexander’s argument. What makes this approach valuable is that redevelopment is not a one-time exercise. Instead of relying on uniform, citywide solutions, urban strategies can be tested within specific neighbourhoods, observed over time, and adjusted based on performance.

The redevelopment of Sarojini Nagar and Netaji Nagar can be understood not as endpoints but as early iterations that can also serve as governance models in a longer process of learning how density can work in the Indian context.

By treating redevelopment as a process of learning and by changing how we think about density, we can start to shift the conversation. The real question is not whether Indian cities will become denser. That is inevitable. The question is whether this density will continue to be seen as a problem, or whether it can be used to create neighbourhoods that are more connected, efficient, and liveable.

The writer is Director, GPM, Architecture & Planner.



Wellness drives the new workplace

From natural light and cleaner air to flexible zones, offices are being designed to boost focus, reduce stress and draw employees back in



Rajat Kapur

The workplace is going through an important but subtle revolution. Efficiency, optimisation of space usage, standardisation, and cost savings were goals that were considered in designing offices until recently. This is now a thing of the past. Luxury offices are embracing wellness architecture as a design philosophy that centres on human health in the workplace.

However, this is not just a matter of aesthetics; it reflects a recognition by companies that their physical space has an impact on their pro-

ductivity and business performance.

The rise

In the post-pandemic world, employee expectations from the workplace have grown. Work is no longer just about output; it is about experience. People now look for jobs that not only help them become competent in their roles but also ensure that they remain mentally stable and physically healthy.

Those organisations having foresight understand that wellness equates to productivity. Studies have proven that exposure to natural light, fresh air, and well-designed

spaces can help reduce stress, improve focus and make workers happy. In today’s tough market environment, where attracting talented people is key, these features are no longer an added advantage but a necessity.

Wellness architecture isn’t limited to design modifications; it entails incorporating the well-being of employees into workplace design. We are witnessing that high-end offices are incorporating design elements such as the use of natural materials and plants to connect with nature in a way that is referred to as biophilic design. Also, sophisticated lighting systems are



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between being productive and feeling well.

All these aspects together enable the creation of an environment that adapts to the employee and not the other way around.

However, one of the challenges that organisations face as they adopt the hybrid way of working has been getting employees back into the physical environment. Wellness architecture has been a significant enabler in this regard. For instance, when the physical environment offers an experience that goes beyond what an individual could achieve at home, the likelihood of getting the employee back into the office space increases. The physical environment is no longer just a place where an individual goes to perform their day job, but has become a destination that offers significant value.

However, investing in wellness architecture is more than just a short-term solution to increase productivity; it is a long-term strategy to create a sustainable work culture. A wellness-driven workspace can help to reduce burnout, increase employee retention, and create a more harmonious organisational culture. It also has a positive impact on brand recognition, as it allows companies to demonstrate their progressive approach to business.

The way we work is changing, and so are our expectations of the workplace. At the forefront of this revolution are high-end offices, which are redefining the concept of going to work every day. They are placing the human experience at the heart of their design and strategy. Wellness architecture is no longer a trend; it is an emerging norm that will define the future of workplaces around the world. And in this new world, it will not be how big an office is that determines its success, but how it can make a difference to those who use it.

The writer is regional managing director, North India, The Executive Centre.

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EC/South-I/260/2025 dated 25.7.2025



WINGFIELD RERA No.
TN/29/Building/0013/2023
dated 4.1.2023
www.rera.tn.gov.in



DELMAR Cheran Nagar Coimbatore

READY TO MOVE IN
VISIT MODEL & FINISHED VILLA

4 BHKs | 2810 - 2954 sq.ft.
Price Starts at 2.67 Crores*



DELMAR RERA No.
TN/11/Building/0189/2018
dated 6.6.2018
www.rera.tn.gov.in



BELMONT RESIDENCES Vadapalani

CONSTRUCTION IN FULL SWING
VISIT MODEL APARTMENT

3 & 4 BHKs | 1947 to 3156 sq.ft.
Price Starts at 3.36 Crores*



BELMONT RERA No.
TN/29/Building/0554/2024
dated 4.12.2024
www.rera.tn.gov.in



KAMADHENU Luz Church Road, Mylapore

CONSTRUCTION IN FULL SWING

3 & 4 BHKs | 2305 to 3753 sq.ft.
Price Starts at 6 Crores*



KAMADHENU RERA No.
TNRERA/29/BLG/0270/2025
dated 8.8.2025
www.rera.tn.gov.in

MALKOHA Guindy

CONSTRUCTION IN FULL SWING
VISIT MODEL APARTMENT

3 & 4 BHKs | 2609 to 3921 sq.ft.
Price Starts at 5.08 Crores*



MALKOHA RERA No.
TN/29/Building/0527/2024
dated 14.11.2024
www.rera.tn.gov.in



SKYLON Koyambedu

CONSTRUCTION IN FULL SWING

3 & 4 BHKs | 1969 to 2887 sq.ft.
Price Starts at 2.55 Crores*



SKYLON RERA No.
TN/29/Building/0589/2024
dated 23.12.2024
www.rera.tn.gov.in

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